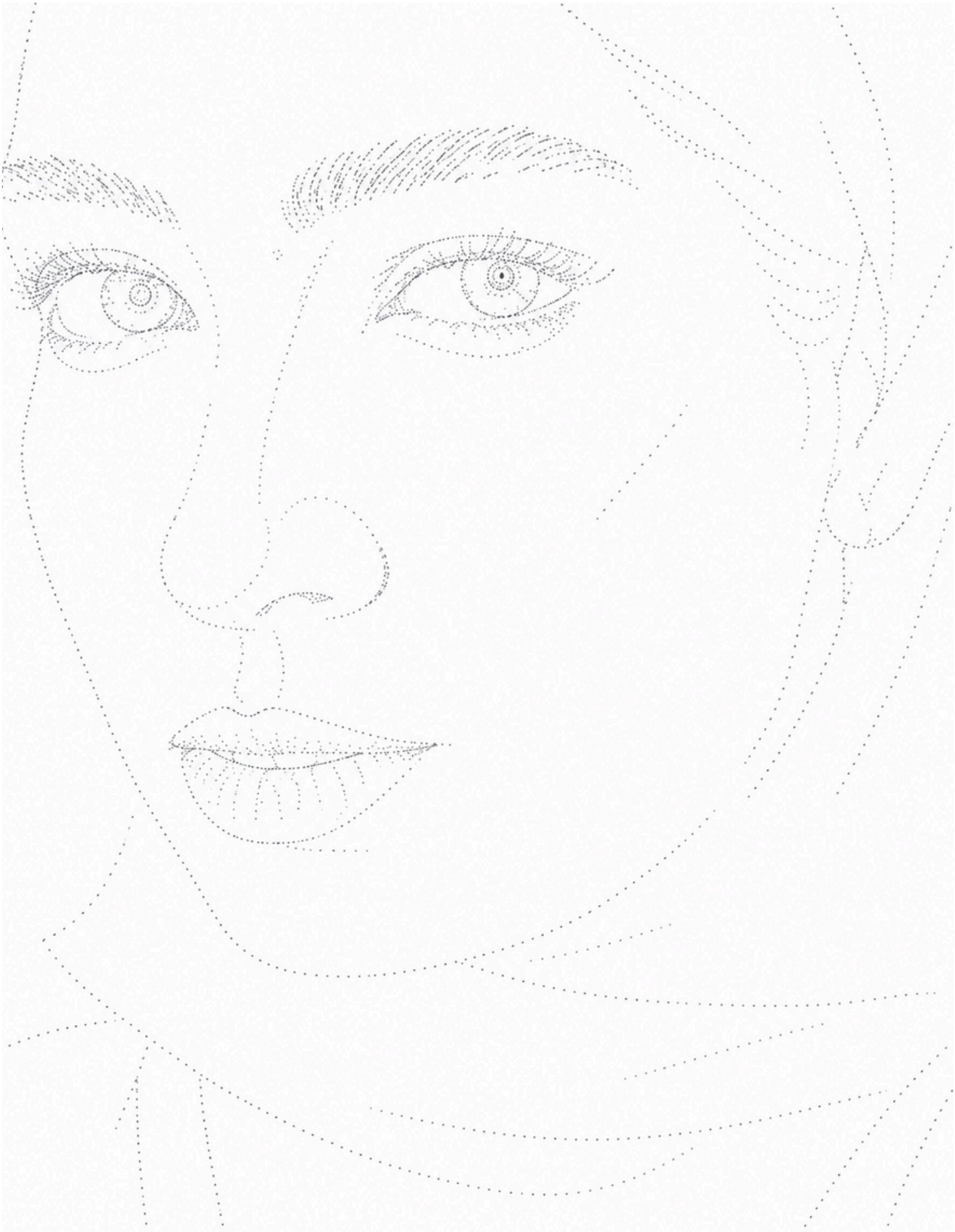
Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



COLORED PENCIL STUDY

a women with purple chocker

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10-14 hours

Subject A woman with calm neutral expression, downward gaze, wearing a deep mulberry garment, photographed from shoulders up with dark background. Hair worn down and over ears, several strands crossing forehead.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

COLOR PALETTE

50% Warm Grey
PC1054
mid-tone base anchor for face, measured light warm value

50% French Grey
PC1072
neutral mid-tone for soft blending and transitions, measured anchor

70% Warm Grey

PC1056

warm light for lit planes and half-tone transition bands, measured anchor

50% Cool Grey

PC1063

cool shadow note in jaw plane and eye orbit, measured anchor

Blush Pink

PC928

vascular warmth anchor for cheeks, nose tip, lips, subsurface scattering

Beige Sienna

PC1080

golden undertone for forehead zone, three-zone temperature map

Clay Rose

PC1017

warm pink vascular mid-face and neck transition warmth

Black Cherry

PC1078

dark chromatic shadow anchor, measured, lash line focal accent

Dahlia Purple

PC1009

saturated dark purple-magenta shadow and core shadow anchor, measured

Tuscan Red

PC937

dark warm magenta-pink shadow and transition, measured anchor

Henna

PC1031

warm dark for shadow transitions and reflected garment bounce

Greyed Lavender
PC1026
cool shadow for jaw plane and cool three-zone temperature anchor

White
PC938
peak highlights and final burnishing melting pass

Cream
PC914
warm peak highlight for forehead and cheekbone tops

Powder Blue
PC1087
cool accent highlight on temple and eye orbit

Magenta
PC930
mid-value moderately saturated hue rotation at plane turns, measured anchor

Black Raspberry
PC1095
very dark magenta-pink for core shadows, measured anchor

Mulberry
PC995
garment hue and colored light bounce onto jaw and neck

Black
PC935
background dark anchor, near-black maximum, measured

10% Warm Grey
PC1050
light background behind lit side for simultaneous contrast

• VALUE GROUPING & LIGHT

VALUE GROUPING & LIGHT

Light source direction

Upper-front to upper-left, creating lit forehead and left cheek (viewer's left) with soft moderate shadows on right cheek and jaw. Light quality is moderately soft, giving wide half-tone zones and rounded form rather than hard shadows. This softness reveals all three temperature zones clearly across planes.



- **V1 · HIGHLIGHT**
  L* 64–80 · 16% of the frame
- **V2 · LIGHT**
  L* 49–64 · 11% of the frame
- **V3 · MIDTONE**
  L* 33–49 · 8% of the frame
- **V4 · SHADOW**
  L* 18–33 · 14% of the frame
- **V5 · CORE DARK**
  L* 2–18 · 51% of the frame

Five groups only. Squint at the photo until it looks like this, then build each group as one value before any local colour — if a passage does not change group, it does not change value.

Edge quality notes

Edges are soft throughout with hardest edge reserved for upper lash line (focal accent per R9 correction). Jaw-to-garment edge is soft with gradual blend into mulberry bounce. Face-to-background edge dissolves into page. Cheek, chin, and jaw edges are progressively softer, creating depth through hierarchy. Lower lash line is deliberately softer and lower-value than upper.

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01

Step 1: Plane Map & Value Structure (Monochrome Foundation)

Entire face, forehead to jaw, excluding surround

Light-pressure monochrome wash using pencil tip and loose circular strokes following plane structure; no feature detail, only value anchors

Light pressure

- Lay monochrome value map at very light pressure using PC1054 50% Warm Grey only. Goal: anchor the full value range—brightest highlights (forehead, cheekbone tops), midtones (front cheek, temple), core shadows (lash line, nostril, jaw bone), reflected light (jaw underplane)—before color enters. This is a VALUE MAP, not a render; planes are suggested by value change, not outlined.
- Identify five planes by their value: frontal planes (forehead, front cheek) are light; top planes (brow ridge, cheekbone peak) are lightest; side planes (temple, side jaw) are mid-to-dark; underplanes (jaw underneath) are mid-value from reflected light; core forms (eye orbit, nostrils) are darkest.
- Use pencil tip to suggest plane edges without hard outlines. Where frontal cheek turns to side jaw, deepen the side value so the boundary reads naturally. The value change implies the edge; do not draw one.
- Preserve paper tooth throughout at light pressure—no heavy darks or burnishing here. Complete map will be faint but show the head's structure clearly in monochrome. When you step back, the three-dimensional form should read even without color.

COLORS PC1054 50% Warm Grey

STOP WHEN

Eye sees distinct planes and complete value range (light to dark) showing head structure · hand uses only light pressure, pencil barely dragging, no scratching sound

✦ *The monochrome foundation is invisible in the final piece but critical to form solidity. Resist darkening; a light foundation now opens your pigment-density budget for 10-20+ layers to come. Darkest values in this step should remain mid-range; you will deepen them progressively in steps 3 onward. This restraint is the difference between a drawing that accepts layers and one that reaches black in step 2 and has nowhere to go.*

02 Step 2: Undertone & Three-Zone Temperature Map

Entire face as three separate zones: forehead, mid-face, jaw/chin

Light-pressure glazing with circular strokes, following zone boundaries but allowing soft overlap at transitions; complete each zone before moving to next

Light pressure

- Establish three-zone temperature map—this teaches the eye that a face is NOT one temperature throughout. Zone 1 (forehead and brow ridge): Lay PC1080 Beige Sienna at light pressure, creating warm-golden undertone anchored in bone proximity. This zone reads warmest in high-key light. Glaze loosely over the entire forehead plane.
- Zone 2 (cheeks, nose, upper lip, upper face): Lay PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure, creating red-pink undertone over the cheek plane, nose side-planes, and upper-lip edge. This zone is vascular and high-blood-flow; it reads warmer and more saturated than forehead. Cover the entire mid-face area with this warm glaze.
- Zone 3 (jaw, side-jaw, chin underplane, lower neck): Lay PC1026 Greyed Lavender at light pressure, creating cool-grey-lavender undertone over side-jaw, jaw underplane, and down into the neck. This zone is denser tissue with lower blood flow; it reads cooler and greyer. This glaze grounds the jaw's temperature separate from the face.
- Feather zone boundaries so they OVERLAP slightly rather than meeting along a hard line. For example, where forehead (warm beige) meets cheek (warm pink), let them overlap in a band so the transition is a color shift, not a seam. This overlap is the precursor to transition hues in step 3.
- Preserve paper tooth; zone hues are laid at light pressure to show through all subsequent layers. They should be visible but subtle—a tint underneath, not a glaze.

COLORS PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1026 Greyed Lavender

TRANSITION

Forehead warms golden · mid-face glows pink · jaw cools lavender-grey—three separate temperatures on one head

STOP WHEN

Each zone reads as its own temperature but blends softly at boundaries · hand maintains light pressure throughout, no pigment buildup

✦ *The three-zone map is the skeleton of warm-to-cool structure. A face laid at one temperature reads flat regardless of value accuracy. These zones stay visible under all*

> *later layers; they are undertones, not covering layers. If pressed hard now, zones muddy and lose clarity. Keep them subtle.*

03 Step 3: Color Build on Frontal & Side Planes (Transition Hues First)

Lit left cheek, shadow right cheek, forehead, chin front, nose side planes

Glaze layers at light-to-medium pressure, one pencil at a time; lay transition hue FIRST across plane boundary, then layer neighbors on either side so transition band shows between them; use circular strokes within a plane, directional strokes (top-to-bottom) across the boundary

Light to Medium pressure

- This step embodies the artist's note on 'color/temperature variety in transitions': each plane gets LIT HUE, TRANSITION HUE at the turning edge, and SHADOW HUE, with the transition hue laid FIRST as a band before neighbors deepen. This is where skin becomes round. Strategy: lit side warm, turning edge rotates in hue and cools, shadow side either warms (reflected light) or cools (if away from bounce).
- LIT LEFT CHEEK: Lay PC1056 70% Warm Grey as glaze over lit cheekbone from temple to front. At the turning edge (where cheek turns away), lay PC930 Magenta as a band across the half-tone—this transition hue shows chromatic shift at plane edge. Then deepen the shadow side (right side of cheek, turning away) with PC1031 Henna or PC1078 Black Cherry at light-to-medium pressure, letting the magenta band show between warm-lit and dark-shadow.
- SHADOW RIGHT CHEEK: Lay PC1063 50% Cool Grey as base cool value over shadow cheek. At the turning edge, lay a warm transition band using PC1031 Henna or PC1017 Clay Rose—this warm band is INSIDE the cool shadow, showing reflected light from garment and ambient. Then deepen the core shadow with PC1078 Black Cherry or PC1009 Dahlia Purple at the jaw bone edge.
- FOREHEAD PLANE: Lay PC1054 50% Warm Grey as mid-light value. At the transition zone where forehead meets temple (turning away), lay PC1080 Beige Sienna or PC928 Blush Pink. In the temple shadow, deepen with PC1026 Greyed Lavender.
- CHIN FRONT PLANE: Lay PC1054 50% Warm Grey as lit value. At the chin edge (where it turns down toward underplane), lay transition band with PC928 Blush Pink or PC1017 Clay Rose. In underplane shadow, use PC1031 Henna to show warm reflected light from garment bounce.
- NOSE SIDE PLANES: Lay lit side (right side, camera's left) in PC1056 70% Warm Grey. At turning edge, lay PC930 Magenta as transition. Shadow side (left side, camera's right) gets PC1078 Black Cherry with warm warmth underneath (PC928 or PC1017) showing subsurface scattering.

COLORS PC1056 70% Warm Grey · PC930 Magenta · PC1031 Henna · PC1078 Black Cherry · PC1063 50% Cool Grey · PC1017 Clay Rose

PC1054 50% Warm Grey · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC928 Blush Pink · PC1026 Greyed Lavender · PC1009 Dahlia Purple

TRANSITION

Lit hue (warm) → TRANSITION HUE: PC930 Magenta at plane turns showing the core shadow (warming the shadow), or PC1017/PC928 Blush Pink/Clay Rose as warm ambient bounce in shadow areas (cooling lit planes, warming shadows) → shadow hue (cool or warm-dark). Plane turns show COLOR ROTATION, not pressure fade. Edges at plane turns COOL outward; edges at reflected-light boundaries WARM inward.

↔ If transition band too subtle, add second pass of its hue at medium pressure. If shadow too dark too soon, swap to lighter pencil (PC1026 Greyed Lavender instead of PC1078) and re-layer.

STOP WHEN

Each plane reads as rounded form with warm-lit side, cool or warm-dark shadow side, and visible transition band of different hue between them · hand transitions from light pressure on lit plane to medium on shadow, with distinct pencil changes marking transitions

✦ *Commonest mistake: omitting transition hue or rushing through it. A plane jumping directly from lit to shadow reads flat. The transition hue is the most important stroke here; name it before picking up pencil: 'I'm laying magenta here to show cheek turning.' That intentionality transfers to the drawing. Transition hue must always be DIFFERENT from both neighbors—it is visual proof the form is turning.*

04 Step 4: Eyes (Iris, Sclera, Lash Line, Specular Highlight)

Both eyes, from lid to under-eye shadow, including lash line and orbital area

Iris: radial strokes from pupil outward with multiple hues layered; sclera: light pressure wash at cool grey, leaving specular highlight untouched; lash line and orbital: directional strokes following lid and orbit contour

Light to Medium pressure

- Build eye as a focal form without final crisp accent (sharpened in step 10). Block pupil and upper-lid cast shadow first using PC1078 Black Cherry at light-to-medium pressure; this shadow defines upper eyelid's forward plane.
- Build iris as radial form with multiple hues (never flat fill). Lay warm base (PC928 Blush Pink or PC1017 Clay Rose) in lower iris, then cooler mid-value (PC1063 50% Cool Grey or PC1087 Powder Blue) in upper iris where it sits in lid shadow. Suggest radial striations by layering these pencils with directional strokes from pupil outward. Iris is a sphere with reflection and shadow.
- Lay sclera (white of eye) using PC1063 50% Cool Grey at light pressure, NOT pure white. Eye sits in skull; its sclera reads as cool grey-white, not brilliant white. This keeps eye from popping off page and maintains head's roundness. Leave small highlight area (specular reflection) untouched; this receives PC938 White in step 10.
- Darken upper lash line by laying PC1078 Black Cherry along upper lid edge at medium pressure. This is NOT yet final sharpened lash line but establishes dark foundation. Lower lash line stays lighter and softer—use PC1063 50% Cool Grey at light pressure, never matching upper darkness.
- Suggest orbital socket shadow above eye using PC1026 Greyed Lavender or PC1087 Powder Blue at light pressure, carving out the cavity around the eye. Below eye, if there is an under-eye shadow or puffiness, render it with PC928 Blush Pink (vascular warmth) or PC1063 50% Cool Grey (shadow), keeping it lighter than upper lid shadow.

COLORS PC1078 Black Cherry · PC928 Blush Pink · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1063 50% Cool Grey · PC1087 Powder Blue

↔ If iris too brown, add PC1087 Powder Blue to upper iris to cool it. If sclera too white, add PC1063 50% Cool Grey as second glaze.

STOP WHEN

Iris shows radial structure (multiple hues, not flat), sclera reads as cool grey-white (not brilliant), upper lash line is darker than lower, orbital shadow reads as distinct cavity · hand has used multiple pencils in iris and maintained pressure control through all layers

> ✦ *Eyes are not carved; they are suggested. Specular highlight (reflection of light source in eye) is sharpest accent in eye and should be small, specific point, not blur. Save for step 10. Eye's personality comes from iris; spend time layering its structure now, and it will reward you with luminosity.*

05 Step 5: Nose & Subsurface Scattering (Thin-Skin Warmth)

Nose tip, nostrils, nose bridge, septum, alar crease

Side-plane strokes following nose's form; warm glaze at tip; cool shadow at alar base; warm interior nostril to show cavity's vascular glow

Light to Medium pressure

- Nose is one of the thinnest-skin areas on face. Light scatters through it, and the tip and nostrils glow warm even in shadow. Build nose as a forward form with subsurface scattering (optical effect of light penetrating translucent skin).
- Lay lit side of nose (right side, camera's left) in PC1056 70% Warm Grey or PC928 Blush Pink at light pressure, following nose's side planes from bridge to tip. This side is most exposed to light and reads warmest.
- At nose tip (turning edge), lay a band of PC928 Blush Pink or PC1017 Clay Rose at medium pressure; this is where subsurface scattering glows warmest. Nose tip should stay lighter and warmer than surrounding shadow, even if technically in shadow.
- Shadow side of nose (left side, camera's right) gets PC1078 Black Cherry or PC1031 Henna at light-to-medium pressure, but the nostrils inside receive warm red-orange or red-brown undertone (PC1031 Henna or PC928 Blush Pink) to show vascular glow inside nostril opening. Nostril is NEVER a black hole; it's a cavity with warm-toned shadow.
- Nose bridge (where nose connects to forehead) reads cooler and lighter, receiving forehead's golden undertone; lay PC1080 Beige Sienna or PC1054 50% Warm Grey here.
- Septum (vertical ridge between nostrils) receives light glaze of PC928 Blush Pink or PC1017 Clay Rose to show its vascular nature.

COLORS PC1056 70% Warm Grey · PC928 Blush Pink · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1078 Black Cherry · PC1031 Henna · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC1054 50% Warm Grey

TRANSITION

Lit side warms (PC928) → tip glows warmest (PC1017 or PC928 at medium) → shadow side cools (PC1078) but retains warm interior (PC1031) to show subsurface scattering

↔ If nose tip too dark, add second glaze of PC928 Blush Pink at light pressure over shadow side, pushing warmth further. If nostrils too black, add PC1031 Henna inside them at light pressure.

STOP WHEN

Nose reads as forward, rounded form; tip is visibly warmer and lighter than surrounding shadow; nostril openings are suggested (not outlined) with warm-toned

interior; nose sits properly on face without looking flat or stuck on · hand has used warm glazes multiple times over shadow side to build subsurface warmth

✦ *Nose is a beacon of warmth on the face. It tells the story of subsurface scattering and directional light. A nose rendered as flat plane or thin line fails to communicate these optical principles. Spend time building its roundness and warmth, and it will anchor entire face's believability.*

06 Step 6: Lips & Mouth Structure (Upper/Lower Separation, Mouth Line)

Lips (upper, lower, cupid's bow, vermillion border), mouth line, visible teeth if any

Lip planes rendered with directional strokes following lip's form; mouth line is an edge (value/color change), not a drawn line; teeth rendered as unified mass with suggested divisions, never individual units

Light to Medium pressure

- Mouth is a complex form with distinct upper and lower planes. Upper lip is ALWAYS darker and cooler than lower lip; this value separation is mandatory. Lower lip is lighter and warmer because it receives more direct light and has exposed, vascular tissue.
- Upper lip: Lay PC1078 Black Cherry or PC937 Tuscan Red at light-to-medium pressure across upper lip form, establishing its darkness and coolness relative to lower lip. Upper lip surface sits in shadow (cast shadow of brow ridge) and reads cooler and more muted.
- Lower lip: Lay PC928 Blush Pink or PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure across lower lip, keeping it lighter and warmer than upper lip. Lower lip glows with warmth because it is vascular and faces upward into light. Add light glaze of PC1054 50% Warm Grey over lit side of lower lip to show its forward plane.
- Cupid's bow (upper lip center): Cupid's bow is highest point of upper lip and catches light; render it slightly lighter than rest of upper lip using PC1031 Henna or PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure, creating subtle highlight that suggests form's peak.
- Mouth line (junction between lips): Mouth line is NOT a hard outline; it emerges from value and color difference. Do not draw a line. Ensure upper lip's cool-dark reads clearly against lower lip's warm-light, and edge will emerge naturally. If needed, very light glaze of PC930 Magenta or PC1026 Greyed Lavender along mouth line (at very light pressure) can soften and enhance junction without outlining it.
- Visible teeth (if any): Render teeth as ONE lit mass (never individual outlined teeth), using PC938 White or PC914 Cream with two or three suggested divisions (shadowed crevices between teeth) using PC1063 50% Cool Grey at light pressure. Tooth mass is unified and sits forward; only the divisions are specific.

COLORS PC1078 Black Cherry · PC937 Tuscan Red · PC928 Blush Pink · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1054 50% Warm Grey · PC1031 Henna · PC1063 50% Cool Grey · PC930 Magenta · PC1026 Greyed Lavender · PC938 White · PC914 Cream

TRANSITION

Upper lip cool-dark → mouth line soft edge (no outline) → lower lip warm-light. Lip line itself is a color transition, not a pencil mark.

↔ If upper lip not dark enough, add second glaze of PC1078 Black Cherry. If lower lip too muted, add PC928 Blush Pink at medium pressure.

STOP WHEN

Upper lip is clearly darker and cooler than lower lip, lower lip glows with warmth, mouth line is soft and not outlined, any visible teeth are rendered as unified lit mass with only suggested crevices · hand maintains light pressure on mouth line so it does not become a hard edge

✦ *Mouth is NOT the most saturated or detailed point on a face, despite emotional importance. Resist urge to render with high saturation or crisp definition; do the opposite. Keep it cool, muted, and soft—let cheeks be the stars. A mouth rendered too saturated or crisp reads as painted mask, not living skin.*

07

Step 7: Jaw, Chin & Shaved-Plane Cool (Jaw Plane Structure & Temperature)

Jaw (side plane from ear forward), chin (front and underplane), shaved-plane temperature (cool, denser tissue)

Jaw side-plane: cool base glaze with warm reflected-light band layered over it; underplane: cool base followed by warm-purple garment bounce; chin: slightly lighter than jaw, with soft transitions; core shadow: directional strokes from jaw to neck

Light to Medium pressure

- Jaw is large bony structure at base of face. Because it is denser tissue with less blood flow than mid-face, it reads cooler and greyer in tone. However, it is NEVER ashy or dead—cool does not mean desaturated. Build jaw as a rounded plane with its own structure.
- Jaw side plane (from ear angle forward along masseter): Lay PC1063 50% Cool Grey as shadow base at light-to-medium pressure, establishing jaw's cool temperature. Then at the edge where jaw turns toward light (zygomatic arch edge), lay a band of PC1031 Henna or PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure to show warm reflected light and ambient fill. This warm band inside cool shadow demonstrates jaw is not all one cool tone—it receives warm bounced light.
- Jaw underplane (underside of jaw, beneath chin): This area receives strongest bounce from mulberry garment. Lay PC1026 Greyed Lavender as cool base, then immediately glaze it with PC995 Mulberry or PC1031 Henna at light pressure to show garment's colored light bouncing upward. This creates rich warm-purple underplane that integrates garment with face.
- Chin (front plane): Chin sits forward and is lit more than jaw. Render it slightly lighter than side-jaw using PC1054 50% Warm Grey or PC928 Blush Pink, establishing its forward position. At turning edge where chin connects to jaw side-plane, lay subtle transition band using PC930 Magenta at very light pressure.
- Core shadow of jaw (deepest recess where jaw meets neck): Use PC1078 Black Cherry or PC1009 Dahlia Purple at medium pressure, darkening contact point between jaw and neck. This shadow is warm-toned (not neutral grey), reflecting garment bounce and warm flesh tones.

COLORS

- PC1063 50% Cool Grey
- PC1031 Henna
- PC1017 Clay Rose
- PC1026 Greyed Lavender
- PC995 Mulberry
- PC1054 50% Warm Grey
- PC928 Blush Pink
- PC930 Magenta
- PC1078 Black Cherry
- PC1009 Dahlia Purple

TRANSITION

Jaw cool (PC1063) → reflected-light warm band (PC1031/PC1017) warming jaw interior, showing ambient light. Underplane cool-grey → mulberry bounce (PC995) warming and coloring it. Core shadow warm-dark (PC1078, not neutral grey).

↔ If jaw too grey/ashy, add glaze of PC1031 Henna or PC928 Blush Pink at light pressure over shadow to restore warmth. If underplane not warm enough, add second glaze of PC995 Mulberry at light pressure.

STOP WHEN

Jaw reads as cooler, denser plane than mid-face; warm reflected-light band is visible INSIDE cool shadow, showing jaw is not uniformly cool; chin reads as forward, lit plane; underplane glows with mulberry warmth · hand has built multiple glaze layers showing interplay of cool shadow and warm ambient/bounce light

✦ *Jaw is where cool and warm meet most dramatically. Resist urge to make jaw uniformly cool; it is only COOLER than mid-face, not absolutely cool. A jaw that is all grey reads as dead zone; a jaw with warm reflected-light band inside cool shadow reads as living tissue receiving ambient light. This is major technical distinction: cool is RELATIVE TEMPERATURE, not absolute state.*

08 Step 8: Neck & Skin-to-Garment Transition (Where the Face Ends)

Neck (front and sides, from jaw to garment), skin-to-garment boundary, contact shadow, mulberry bounce

Neck: warm cylindrical form with light on top, shadow on sides, gestural strokes following neck's axis; skin-to-garment: contact shadow (warm-toned dark line), soft blend; garment bounce: glaze of mulberry over shadow areas; garment: broad strokes of main hue, one fold shadow

Light to Medium pressure

- Neck is continuation of face and body, bridging head to garment. It is typically warmer and longer than first impression suggests. Render it as warm cylindrical form with light on top (where it catches key light) and shadow on sides and beneath.
- Neck front plane (lit side): Lay PC1054 50% Warm Grey or PC928 Blush Pink at light pressure, establishing neck's warm tone. Neck is vascular like face, so it reads warmer than jaw. Add glaze of PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure to enhance warmth.
- Neck shadow (side or underplane): Where neck turns away from light or dips beneath jaw, lay PC1031 Henna or PC1078 Black Cherry at light-to-medium pressure. Keep this shadow warm-toned, not neutral grey, reflecting garment bounce and ambient warmth.
- Skin-to-garment contact shadow: Where neck meets mulberry garment, there is a contact shadow (thin dark line) and sharp temperature change. Lay PC1009 Dahlia Purple or PC1078 Black Cherry at skin-to-fabric junction, establishing boundary. This shadow is warm-purple (from garment's influence), not black.
- Garment bounce on jaw and neck: Mulberry garment casts colored light upward onto lower jaw, neck, and chin underplane. This is built in earlier steps but reinforced here: ensure mulberry's hue is visible as warm-purple glaze on jaw underplane and lower neck. Use PC995 Mulberry at light pressure, allowing it to shift local color of shadow areas.
- Garment silhouette: Render visible garment area (shoulders and upper chest) using PC995 Mulberry as main hue, with PC1078 Black Cherry or PC1009 Dahlia Purple for shadow folds at neck and shoulders. Keep garment rendering minimal and gestural (not detailed); face is priority. One fold shadow at neck suffices to define garment's volume.

COLORS PC1054 50% Warm Grey · PC928 Blush Pink · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1031 Henna · PC1078 Black Cherry · PC1009 Dahlia Purple · PC995 Mulberry

TRANSITION

Face cool-to-warm in planes → neck warmer in overall tone → skin-to-garment edge cools and darkens (mulberry influence) → garment bounce warms underplane. Neck acts as thermal bridge between face and garment.

↔ If neck too warm, add glaze of PC1063 50% Cool Grey at side-neck shadow. If garment bounce not visible, add second glaze of PC995 Mulberry at light pressure over jaw underplane.

STOP WHEN

Neck reads as warm, cylindrical form continuous with face; skin-to-garment boundary is clear (slight darkening and color shift); mulberry bounce is visible as warm-purple glaze on jaw and neck underplane; garment is suggested with one fold shadow, not rendered in detail · hand has used warm tones throughout neck and maintained mulberry's influence on shadows

✦ *Skin-to-garment transition is hard boundary on real head but soft edge in drawing. Build transition as warm contact shadow that hints at boundary rather than outlining it. Garment's colored light (the bounce) is tool for integrating garment with face; use it to unify two halves of composition.*

09 Step 9: Surround (Hair, Background, Garment Gesture)

Hair mass (forehead strands, side hair), background (upper and side), garment (shoulders, upper chest)

Hair: gestural mass with dark anchor at scalp, mid tones in body, tooth showing at silhouette; background: light-to-dark wash with soft outer edge, no outline; garment: solid mid-tone with one fold shadow, no texture detail

Light to Medium (lighter than face) pressure

- Surround (hair, background, garment) is GESTURAL and ECONOMICAL. Three values maximum per area; 2-4 pencils; open strokes showing tooth on purpose; never burnished. Goal is to frame the face with value range and anchors without competing for detail with head.
- HAIR: Artist noted 'several strands on forehead', implying hair is DOWN with specific forelock texture. Do NOT render hair strand by strand. Anchor hairline with dark line (PC1078 Black Cherry at scalp edge, where hair meets forehead), then fill in hair mass with broad gestural strokes. Use PC1078 Black Cherry for main hair shadow (dark anchor), PC1031 Henna or PC1056 70% Warm Grey for mid-tone hair masses, and leave paper showing for brightest hair highlights (where light reflects off hair's surface). Strands on forehead are suggested (not drawn individually) by lifting darkest line slightly where each strand's edge catches light.
- BACKGROUND: Background should be darker on side of face lit by main light (to make lit side pop) and lighter on shadow side (simultaneous contrast). Block in background using PC935 Black at upper-left and side, fading to PC1050 10% Warm Grey or paper on upper-right (behind lit side). Use open, gestural strokes; no tight rendering. Background boundary should be soft and fading, not hard edge against bare paper.
- BACKGROUND TONE RANGE: Ensure background reads darker than face's average tone, so head does not float. Darkest background should be at jaw level or lower (where it meets garment), creating frame around face.
- GARMENT: Already partially rendered in step 8, but complete it here at gestural level. Use PC995 Mulberry for main garment area, PC1078 Black Cherry or PC1009 Dahlia Purple for ONE shadow fold at neck or shoulder, and leave most of garment as simple mid-value plane. Do NOT render texture, buttons, or detail; garment's sole job is to frame face and provide colored bounce light.
- SOFT BOUNDARY: Ensure at least one edge (often side hair-to-background edge) dissolves softly into page, with no hard line. This prevents 'cut-out' look where head is pasted onto bare paper.

COLORS PC1078 Black Cherry · PC1031 Henna · PC1056 70% Warm Grey · PC935 Black · PC1050 10% Warm Grey · PC995 Mulberry

PC1009 Dahlia Purple

↔ If background too light, add second pass of PC935 Black. If hair too uniform, add few mid-tone strokes of PC1031 Henna at light pressure to suggest internal volume. If garment blend too abrupt, add soft glaze of PC1009 Dahlia Purple at neck fold.

STOP WHEN

Face sits clearly in space with value range around it (darker background on lit side, lighter on shadow side); hair reads as unified mass with one dark anchor, not individual strands; background fades softly at outer edge with no hard boundary against bare paper; garment is suggested in one flat hue with one fold, not rendered in detail · hand has used open strokes throughout, pencil not dragging heavy

✦ *Surround is done when face reads in space, not when surround is 'perfect'. Resist urge to render every hair or every background nuance. Detail budget lives on face. Gestural, anchored surround that frames face without competing for attention is far more sophisticated than equally rendered head and background. Accumulation-of-loops correction R11 says: 'The surround needs its own value RANGE, an anchor where it meets the face, and at least ONE boundary that leaves the page softly.' Meet these three criteria and stop.*

10 Step 10: Edge Hierarchy, Burnish Face, Re-Punch Darks & Peak Highlights (Final Integration & Focal Accent)

Entire face (burnish, re-punch, highlight) and edges throughout page

Burnish: heavy-pressure circular strokes with PC938 White, face only. Re-punch: medium-heavy pressure with PC1078/PC1095 at specific dark notes (lash line, nostrils, mouth shadow, jaw shadow). Lash line: crisp, hard line with sharp pencil. Highlights: small, specific points of PC938 White. Softening: kneaded eraser or light warm glaze over any too-crisp edges.

Heavy (burnish and lash line), Medium-Heavy (re-punch), Light (edge softening) pressure

- This final step unifies face, sharpens focal accent, and cements depth through edge hierarchy. Four sub-passes: (1) light burnish on entire face to smooth and integrate layers, (2) immediate re-punching of darkest darks (which burnishing lightens), (3) sharpening focal accent (upper lash line), (4) adding peak highlights and reviewing whole.
- BURNISH PASS: Using PC938 White at HEAVY PRESSURE (firmly dragging pencil in loose circular strokes), move across entire face from forehead to jaw, melting wax layers into smooth, painted finish. This removes wax bloom (chalky surface) and creates luminosity. DO NOT burnish surround (hair, background); burnishing is FACE ONLY. As you burnish, face will appear to lighten; this is expected and necessary.
- RE-PUNCH DARKS PASS (IMMEDIATE, before step 3): Moment burnishing completes, re-punch darkest face notes using PC1078 Black Cherry or PC1095 Black Raspberry at MEDIUM-HEAVY PRESSURE. These are: (1) upper lash line (both eyes), (2) nostrils (interior shadows), (3) mouth line shadow (below lower lip), (4) core shadow at jaw-neck contact, (5) any cast shadow from brow ridge over eyes. This pass is NOT about darkening whole face; it is about recapturing VALUE RANGE that burnish lightened. Burnishing without re-punching loses depth.
- SHARPEN THE FOCAL ACCENT (UPPER LASH LINE): Using PC1078 Black Cherry or PC1095 Black Raspberry at HEAVY PRESSURE and sharp pencil point, draw crisp, hard line along upper lash line (edge of upper eyelid). This line should be sharpest, most defined mark on entire page. Per accumulated-loop correction R9: 'Detail is a BUDGET: name single sharpest mark on page (normally upper lash line in final step), and say which secondary form must give detail UP.' Lash line is SHARP; everything else is soft. This sharpness telegraphs to viewer: 'Look here first.' Lower lash line stays soft and lower in value, never mirrored.
- EDGE HIERARCHY PASS: Review all edges on page. Soft and lost edges should predominate (forehead-to-background, cheek-to-hair, jaw-to-neck, etc.). Only upper lash line is HARD. Any other edges too crisp (cheek edge, chin edge, jaw line) should be softened by: lifting them back with kneaded eraser rolled to point, or layering warm-tone pencil (PC1031 Henna, PC928 Blush Pink, or PC1080 Beige Sienna) at light pressure over edge to blur it. Soft edges recede and create depth; hard edges advance. Control edge sharpness to control depth.

- PEAK HIGHLIGHTS: Add specular highlights (bright reflection of light source) using PC938 White at MEDIUM-HEAVY PRESSURE. These are small, specific points: (1) one in each eye (reflection), usually at upper-inner or upper-outer of iris, (2) on forehead cheekbone top (one small point), (3) on nose tip if it catches peak highlight. These are SMALL and BRIGHT, not broad areas. Peak highlight on cheekbone should create hard value jump from surrounding value—this jump telegraphs 'light hitting here.' Use PC914 Cream instead of pure white on forehead if it reads too cool.
- WARM RE-PUNCH (OPTIONAL): If shadows read too cool or ashy after re-punching, add thin glaze of PC1031 Henna or PC1080 Beige Sienna over shadows at LIGHT PRESSURE to restore warmth. This is refinement only, not re-render.
- FINAL REVIEW: Step back and compare drawing to reference. Check: (1) Value range—do highlights and shadows match reference's depth? (2) Temperature—does face show three distinct zones (warm forehead, pink mid-face, cool jaw)? (3) Transitions—are there visible transition hues at plane turns, or does face fade smoothly? (4) Edge hierarchy—is lash line sharpest mark? (5) Presence—does head sit in space, or does it float? Make minor refinements (glaze here, lifted edge there) as needed.

COLORS PC938 White · PC1078 Black Cherry · PC1095 Black Raspberry · PC914 Cream · PC1031 Henna · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC928 Blush Pink

↔ If face too cool after burnishing, add glaze of PC1080 Beige Sienna at light pressure. If lash line not dark enough, add second pass of PC1095 Black Raspberry. If highlights too large, use eraser to lift them back and re-place them smaller.

STOP WHEN

Face is smooth and integrated (burnish complete and wax bloom gone, re-punch complete), upper lash line is single sharpest mark on page, all other edges are soft or lost, peak highlights are small and bright creating hard value jumps, face reads with full depth and presence · hand has completed burnishing (no chalky surface remains) and re-punching (darks are recaptured), and feels confident in edge hierarchy

✦ *This step is where many advanced drawings fail. Burnish MUST be followed immediately by re-punching; if you leave face burnished but not re-punched, it will look flat and washed out. Burnish creates smoothness and luminosity, but re-punch recaptures depth. Neither one without other is complete. Focal accent (lash line sharpness) is final gesture that says 'this is finished and intentional, not just rendered.' That crisp line is worth the effort.*

WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.